

What is a Curriculum vitae?

A Curriculum vitae (CV) is a marketing tool and may be one of the most important documents that you write in your professional life. It is the sum and substance of your work history and education and indicates a particular career direction.



It should demonstrate credibility and be interesting. Because your CV is like a personal advertisement, it should convince a potential employer that you are an outstanding candidate for the job and that you will contribute to the organization.

Your CV has to sell you in short order. While you may have all the requirements for a particular position, your CV is a failure if the employer does not instantly come to the conclusion that you "have what it takes." The first hurdle your CV has to pass - whether it ends up in the "consider file" or the "reject file" - may take less than thirty seconds.

To prepare a successful CV, you need to know how to review, summarize, and present your experiences and achievements on one page. Unless you have considerable experience, you don't need two pages. Outline your achievements briefly and concisely.

Your CV is your ticket to an interview where you can sell yourself!

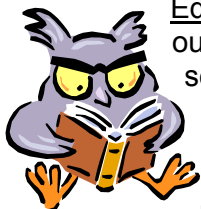
What your Curriculum vitae should include:

Personal data The only required information is your name, address, phone number, and e-mail address. Be sure to provide both permanent and current address, and the telephone numbers.

Career objective An objective tells potential employers the sort of work you are hoping to do. A concise statement indicating your career goals is recommended if you have specific career desires. Otherwise, include your objective in your cover letter to a specific employer or for a specific job.



Summary of skills/professional expertise A concise statement highlighting your strongest skills and areas of professional expertise can be an advantage to you, especially if you have a mix of experiences in your career history.



Education One rule of thumb is that unless you are more than five years out of school, your education section should precede your experience section. List the names of the institutions you attended with the most recent listed first. List the degree received plus your major area of study. Include special programs from your university, such as junior year abroad, a six-month internship, etc. Indicate either the degree name or the degree initials. Indicate the area of specialization or major after the degree title. Include the thesis topic in *italics* if it relates to your professional goals. Mention academic honours including a brief explanation of honours or awards that are not self-explanatory, particularly for international students. It is not necessary to include your grade point average unless requested by an employer.

Work experience Internships and volunteer experience can be considered in this section if they relate to your professional goals, or you can create a section called "Additional or Related Experience," or "Community Service." In a CV, work and education may be listed in chronological order however many employers prefer the reverse chronological order (put your last job first and work backward to your first). It should include title of position, name of organization, location of work (town, state), dates of employment, describe your work responsibilities with emphasis on specific skills and achievements. When describing work experience, summarize your accomplishments rather than listing job tasks. Students and recent graduates often fail to make an effective presentation of their experience because they use too narrow a definition of work experience. First of all, relevant "work" experience is in no way limited to paid employment. Also consider including nonpaid work, volunteer work, part-time and temporary positions, internships, unstructured work, self-employment, odd jobs, and miscellaneous informal services you may have provided to your academic department or a favoured professor.



Publications List those publications that relate directly to your career goal. Employers most interested in publications will be teaching hospitals, research organizations, consulting, and international organizations. It is usually recommended to create a separate list and indicate on your resume that publications are available upon request.

Computer skills It is advisable to provide information about your computer skills.

Languages If you are fluent or conversant in several languages, list the languages you speak and/or write as follows: "Fluent in French, proficient in Japanese, knowledgeable in Spanish." Think carefully about your level of proficiency. Do not overrate your skills as you may be asked to demonstrate your language ability during an interview.



Interests One or two lines about your outside interests, hobbies, or travels can sometimes add interesting information to the interview and may spark conversation.



You may add key or special skills or competencies, leadership experience in volunteer organizations. Generally, avoid information about your marital status, children, or age in this section (unless you feel it is relevant to the work you will be expected to do).

References You can write "References Available upon Request" if you have space. Employers will ask directly for references, so prepare a list with names, titles, addresses, and telephone/fax numbers. Ask people if they are willing to serve as references before you give their names to a potential employer. Give careful consideration to your choice of references, as some will be more appropriate to an employer than others.

Curriculum vitae Writing Tips

Content

- Run a spell check on your computer before anyone sees your resume.
- Get a friend (an English major would do nicely) to do a grammar review.
- Ask another friend to proofread. The more people who see your resume, the more likely that misspelled words and awkward phrases will be seen (and corrected).
- The use of power verbs denote that you took action. Examples include words like "*accomplished*," "*achieved*," and "*managed*." When reviewers see these action words, they realize that you are a person that takes initiative: you are a self-starter.
- The use of power words helps measure the result of the actions you took. Examples of power words are "*positive*," "*results*," and "*significant*."
- Emphasize your recent work experience. In today's changing world, reviewers don't care what you were doing fifteen-twenty years ago.
- Try to highlight your strengths, and minimize your weaknesses.



Design These tips will make your resume easier to read and/or scan into an employer's data base.

- Use white or off-white paper.
- Use 8-1/2- x 11-inch paper.
- Print on one side of the paper.
- Use a friendly font (Arial, Times or Courier) size of 10 to 14 points
- Use nondecorative typefaces.
- Choose one typeface and stick to it.
- Avoid italics, script, and underlined words
- Do not use horizontal or vertical lines, graphics, or shading.
- Do not fold or staple your resume.
- If you must mail your resume, put it in a large envelope
- There is no consensus as to what length your resume should be. The length depends on the depth and scope of your individual experiences. Try to keep it to either one full page or two full pages. Leaving it at 1½ pages isn't as professional as one or two full pages.
- Keep paragraphs brief: no more than five to six lines. If you have a long paragraph on your resume, break it up into several shorter ones. Eliminate every unnecessary word.



Putting your resume/CV on-line Once you are satisfied with your resume/CV you should consider putting it online. There are a number of international recruitment agencies that will post your resume for free on the internet

Sample Curriculum Vitae

NAME
Address
Phone Number
Email

SUMMARY STATEMENT *(Optional)*
Discusses key strengths

EDUCATION:

Date **Harvard School of Public Health**, Boston, MA
Ph.D Degree Concentration,
Dissertation

Date **Institution**, City, State
MA Degree Major
Thesis

Date **Institution**, City, State
BA/BS Degree Major

POSTDOCTORAL TRAINING *(If applicable)*

FELLOWSHIPS

Dates Field of Research Place Title

INTERNSHIPS/RESIDENCIES

Dates Specialty Hospital

LICENSURE/CERTIFICATION *(If applicable)*

Date Type of License or Certification

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

TITLE Date

Place, City, State

Description of responsibilities, leadership roles

PUBLICATIONS

Use standard format

PAPERS PRESENTED

GRANTS/AWARDS

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

SKILLS

LANGUAGES

COMPUTER

References

Altavista Careers (2001), JobsontheWeb(2001), Virtualville (2001) and MIT Online Resources (2001)